

Assignment: Journaling – Critical Thinking

Reflection Journal

1. Identify the biases that you are now able to relate to in your past experience. List the top three biases.

After going through the critical thinking module, I was able to clearly identify a few biases that influenced my past decisions. The first one is confirmation bias, where I tended to look for information that supported my initial assumptions while ignoring conflicting signals. The second bias I relate to is anchoring bias, especially during technical discussions, where the first suggested solution strongly influenced the final approach, even if better options emerged later. The third bias is availability bias, where recent incidents or visible issues shaped my judgment more than actual data trends. Becoming aware of these biases has made me reflect on how often decisions are made based on mental shortcuts rather than objective evaluation. This awareness has already helped me slow down, question my assumptions, and rely more on data and alternate viewpoints.

2. Did you catch yourself when you went through Fast (Non-Conscious) Thinking and Slow (Deliberate) Thinking? Share your experience.

Yes, this training helped me clearly recognise moments when I shifted between fast and slow thinking. Fast thinking usually showed up during routine work, such as responding to familiar issues or reacting in meetings where time felt limited. While fast thinking helped with efficiency, I noticed it sometimes led to oversights. Slow thinking, on the other hand, required conscious effort and was more evident when analyzing complex issues or unfamiliar problems. I recall revisiting a technical decision recently and deliberately slowing down to review assumptions, alternatives, and risks. Although it took more time, the outcome was more structured and reliable. This experience taught me that effective critical thinking lies in knowing when to slow down rather than relying purely on instinct.

3. Do you think eliminating emotions completely would be the right way to think critically? Share your experiences.

I do not believe eliminating emotions entirely is the right approach to critical thinking. Emotions provide valuable context, especially when decisions impact people and not just systems or processes. Earlier, I tried to suppress emotions to remain 'logical,' but this often resulted in overlooking human factors such as team morale and stakeholder expectations. Through this module, I realised that the goal is not to remove emotions but to recognise and manage them. In one situation, acknowledging frustration allowed me to pause and reassess a problem more calmly. By doing so, I was able to separate emotional reactions from factual analysis. This balance helped me make decisions that were both rational and empathetic, leading to better overall outcomes.

4. Pick a problem or bug that you worked on a few months back. With this new awareness, how would you define the problem statement better today? Which method helped you?

A few months ago, I worked on a recurring performance issue that was initially labeled as a system latency bug. With my current understanding of critical thinking, I realise the problem statement was vague and solution-oriented. Today, I would redefine it by focusing on observable symptoms, impact, and context instead of assumptions. I would clearly state when the issue occurs, under what conditions, and who or what is affected. The method that helped me most was breaking down the problem using structured questioning, such as asking 'what is happening' versus 'why it is happening.' This approach helps avoid premature conclusions and leads to more accurate root cause analysis and sustainable solutions.